

The Council's own table sends for you tonight – and for once it is not an errand into the dark, but a reckoning of errands already gone. In the days before the bells, five towns of the Prussian league each sent word across the water, every one to an old friend, every one begging the same thing: stand with us when it comes. Four friends have answered. The fifth envoy has not been heard of since the day he rode out – and no one at that table can name which of the five roads has swallowed him.

They send you down the Broad Street to find his name, and you go with your hood up and your ears open, the way couriers learn to. What drifts off the doorsteps does not sit easy. Two well-fed men on a step, laughing: that the great houses have the painters in already – quartering shields, arguing over crests – for burghers no longer, they mean to come out of this rising as gentlefolk, with arms above the gate and a seat at the tournament. A draper, lower and sourer: that those same houses make every stranger lay his goods out a week in our market before he may pass on, the better to sell their own the dearer – justice for the rich, he says, and a toll for everyone else. An old woman, plainly, as you pass: that whatever the lords win out of this, it will be a lord who keeps it, and never the likes of her. None of them know whose letters you carry tonight. You are not certain, just now, that you would want them to.

Folded into your orders is the hand of the Council's clerk, and it tells you the rest:

Friends – five of our league sent abroad before the rising, each man to the Hansa city that has ever been its sister; for it is an old courtesy that town greets town by its arms, and each was sent to the shield that mirrors his own. Word has come back from four. Hamburg has answered. Kolonia has answered. And Lubeka, twice over. But five rode out, and one is silent on the road – taken, drowned, or turned, we cannot tell – and we cannot send aid down a road we cannot name. Go where the brotherhood has set the arms of every friendly city into the stone of the street. Find there the shield of each town that answered, and set beside it the sister-shield it mirrors among our own five – Gdańsk, Królewiec, Elbląg, Chełmno, and Toruń. Four of ours will so be matched to a friend who answered. The fifth – the one

whose sister stayed silent — is the man we have lost. Bring me that
city's name.

You walk the painted stones one by one. They are no secret — they lie open underfoot for any reveller to tread on, and the whole street is too busy dancing to wonder why you read them. There is Toruń's own gate and its three towers; and far down the row, the white castle of Hamburg that is its very twin, tower for tower. So it goes for the rest, if you have the eye — like to like, our own to their friend across the sea. Match the four that answered to their sisters among our five, and the one city left standing alone is the road that gave no answer.

And the thought you keep pushing down rises again, here among the proud little shields underfoot: that these are the men you serve — the ones with the painters in, dreaming of crests and tournaments while smaller folk count the cost — and that you carry their rising on your own back through the cold. Whose cause is this, in truth, and are they the ones in the right? You push it down. It does not go far.

↪ GAME MASTER — Bring the name of the silent city to the Game Master, who keeps to the Rynek Staromiejski (the Old Town market square). Name the road that swallowed the Council's envoy, and what was waiting on his answer will be given to you in return — and with it, your next orders.